though the latter was.

As per the Government of India rules, Saina was eligible for, and deserving of, her seat on three counts. First, by virtue of her domicile, having acquired her higher secondary education in Mizoram; second, by virtue of her being the daughter of an officer of the union territory cadre posted to the state of Mizoram; and third, and the most important, by virtue of her merit in the board examinations. The Central Government had allocated thirteen seats to Mizoram and there was no way anyone could deprive Saina of her due. This sense of surety went a long way in diluting the uncertainty created by a long wait for both the mother and the daughter.

The order of 4 August 1992, for the Central pool MBBS and Bachelor of Dental Surgery (BDS) seats for the state of Mizoram for the year 1992–93, clearly states '*… that the States/UTs should nominate their candidates on the basis of the merit system devised by the Government of India; the children of all-India service officers would also be eligible to participate in the said merit system.'*

On this basis, Saina was allotted a seat on 11 August 1992, which was subsequently notified to be cancelled on 15 September 1992.

Word got through to Kiran Bedi that Chief Minister Lal Thanhawla was apparently angry with her and, therefore, as a form of punishment, he was in no mood to grant her daughter her due. This development gave a new turn to the whole incident and Kiran would wonder as to why on God's earth the CM was annoyed with her. Grapevines function for just this sort of a situation and the reasons soon reached her.

Kiran had discovered exemplary qualities in an officer under her charge. In her view he was the most outstanding of all the police officers in her range. She found him to be alert and quick to grasp strategies, possessed initiative and exhibited good leadership qualities. Over and above these features, she also found him to be highly welfare-oriented. In one of her monthly meetings with officers of her range, where this particular officer was representing his battalion, he mentioned to her how he was being harassed and mistreated by his SP. The DIG (Range) called up the SP and asked him for an explanation. Because the young officer concerned was a non-Mizo, the SP was quick to proclaim to one and all that discrimination was being exercised against a Mizo official by a non-Mizo superior. The SP who had earlier shown contempt for her concept of introducing prayer meetings for Mizo criminals was quick to join forces with like-minded people on the issue. They took the matter up to their political bosses.

Yet another incident seemed to irk the Mizoram Government. The additional SP (Prosecution), a Mizo officer this time, was supervising court operations from his office located at some distance from the courts. His deputy SP, who functioned from the court office, was therefore his own boss and had, consequently, lowered efficiency to an extremely low pitch. The ASP could not do much about such a situation due to lack of proximity. Kiran advised him to shift his office to the court so that a modicum of efficiency could be restored. This step was not in the least appreciated by the DSP who suddenly realized that he was now expected to not only attend office regularly but also to actually work. He also joined forces with the aforementioned SPs and added a new dimension to the entire episode; i.e., Kiran not just discriminating against Mizo officers but also taking on powers of the government in transferring an ASP.

The CM promptly issued orders that the ASP was to revert to his earlier office. A hapless and much harassed ASP came back to Kiran and expressed his annoyance. She told him to go and explain to the CM that he had never been transferred in the first place but had merely been required to shift his office in order to ensure proper surveillance and efficiency in the disposal of court cases. He did